

a virtual machine created by the developers of the Zork game to fit their expansive — though text-based — game in the meagre amounts of RAM on those systems.

The Z-machine allows for the creation text adventures where one types commands and reads text descriptions in order to complete puzzles. They are the precursor to modern adventure and role playing games.

To play those games today, one can either run the original game code in an emulator, or use a modern z-machine emulator like Frotz. This would also allow you to play such games on a mobile phone.

Z-machine isn't the only such system though. There are many others such as TADS, Hugo, Glulxe etc. The best way to dive into interactive fiction today is to check out Gargoyle, a software package that collects many interpreters in one package that has a GUI and works on Windows and Linux.

Now that we've looked at some ways to emulate compatible software, lets go back to that other method, of emulating the entire machine rather than just the software, and expand on that as well.

Emulating History

Emulating old outdated operating systems is easier said than done. The problem isn't that running games inside a VM running an old OS will be too slow. Games that old have requirements low enough that this isn't an issue. Windows 98 and all its apps could easily run in 64MB of RAM, which would easily be consumed by a single open tab in a modern browser today.

The issue is that it is hard to get a new legal copy of these old versions of Windows. Microsoft no longer sells these products so might feel yourself justified in just getting a copy off of a torrent. This is some grey area that we'd rather not traverse. If you have a copy Windows XP is a better bet than recent Windows versions for running old software since it is the bridge between modern NT based Windows and the old DOS-based Windows 3.1 / 9x.

For old DOS-based games, the best solution is DOSBox, and it is unlikely you will ever need anything other than this one. It is such a great DOS emulator that you can even install Windows 95 / 98 over it and have it running in DOSBox! It is also used by games that are available on GOG.com and on Steam to make old games playable on newer systems.

Since DOSBox is a command line tool, you will either need to get comfortable with creating and editing config files and learning how to work with its various parameters in order to set up the environment that your game